

fibre-optic lines. It was first used for TV, and is now also being used for Internet access. Cable can transfer data downstream to a computer at speeds as fast as 27Mbps, much faster than DSL can. The actual speed a user gets, however, depends on variables including the modem's throughput capability, the maximum throughput per user that the cable service sets, and the number of other users sharing a neighbourhood connection at any time.

CDMA

Code Division Multiple Access. CDMA is a digital spread-spectrum modulation technique used mainly with personal communications devices such as mobile phones. CDMA digitises a conversation, and tags it with a special frequency code. The data is then scattered across the frequency band in a pseudo-random pattern. In order to reconstruct the signal, the receiving device is instructed to decipher only the data corresponding to a particular code.

Client

The 'customer' side of a client/server setup. When you log on to a server, the word client can refer to you, to your computer, or to the software running on your computer. For example, to download something from an FTP site, you use FTP client software; the FTP site runs FTP server software.

Decibel or dB

A logarithmic ratio that indicates the relative strength of a device's electric or acoustic signal to that of another. It can be used by itself, but is often paired with a specific unit of measure, such as a milliwatt (dBm) or an isotropic antenna (dBi). The higher a device's decibel rating, the more powerful its signal.

dBi

Decibels compared to an isotropic antenna. An antenna's gain is often measured in decibel strength compared to an isotropic antenna, a theoretical, perfect antenna whose range is 360 degrees in all directions. The higher the dBi, the stronger the antenna.